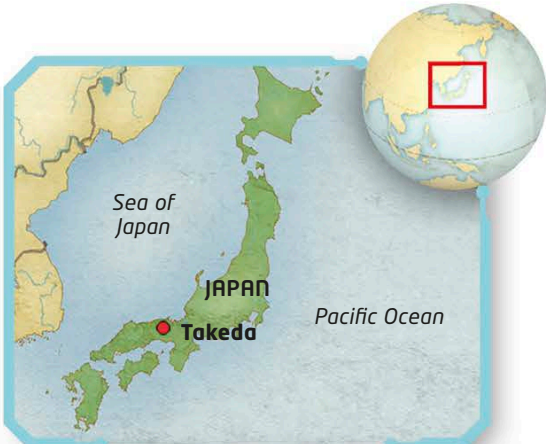


JAPANESE FORTRESS

Perched above a sea of clouds, the ruins of Takeda Castle hug the contours of their hilltop home. This mountain fortress was first built in 1441, then had immense stone walls built to improve its defenses in about 1585. These alterations were made during a period of civil unrest when castles were being built and strengthened across Japan.

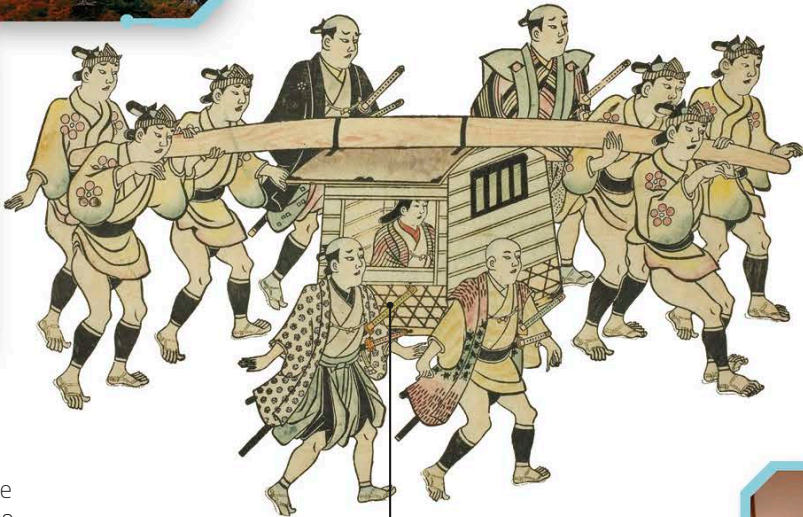


Strategic location
Takeda Castle is in the west of Honshu, Japan's central island. It sits on a mountain ridge 1,158 ft (353 m) above sea level, overlooking a highway.



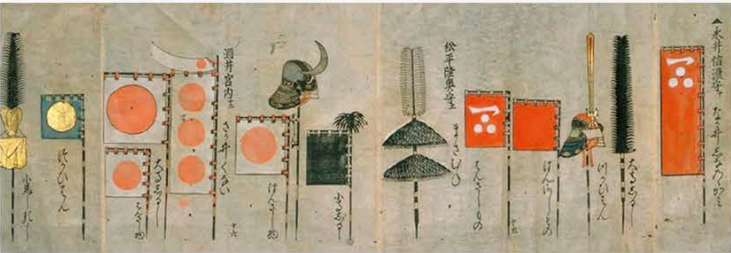
Superb structures
Most Japanese castles had some features in common: a central keep; several courtyards; then walls, watchtowers, and ditches. This is Himeji Castle, which has been restored to look as it did in its prime.

Organized society
Japan had a class-based system. Groups of people such as warriors, farmers, artisans, and merchants were clearly separate, with strict rules on what each group could do. At the top of society were lords called *daimyo*, served by samurai warriors.



This *daimyo* is too important to walk—he is being carried in the middle of a group of his retainers.

Battle flags
Daimyo led armies of samurai on the battlefield. Each *daimyo* had his own standard. As the selection below shows, these could be flags, fans, or helmets. Displayed on a tall pole, standards showed which *daimyo* were present at a battle.



Inside the castle
The rooms in the castle's keep were comfortably furnished with paper walls and soft floor mats. *Daimyo* showed off their wealth by decorating their rooms with the finest paintings, such as the one on the back wall of this reconstructed room.

